

Exercise 1: design your own agent

Now that you have built one agent step by step, design an agent that could solve a real recurring problem in your work. You do not need to build it fully today. The goal is to leave with a clear blueprint you could hand to somebody else.

Step 1. Choose the job

Start with the problem rather than the technology. Choose one recurring task where you repeatedly need similar instructions, knowledge, judgement or output.

Agent type	What it is for	Example
Knowledge	Finding and explaining information from a defined body of trusted material	Answer questions using approved (ORGANISATION) publications
Research	Investigating a question across sources and synthesising findings	Background research for a speech, interview or briefing
Editorial	Producing recurring communications to consistent rules and style	Turn source material into web copy, social posts or internal notes
Specialist adviser	Applying a defined method to recurring requests	Speechwriting assistant, media-response adviser, content reviewer
Review	Checking work against defined criteria	Review drafts for accuracy, tone, source adherence and clarity
Radar	Watching for change and surfacing what matters	A weekly scan of EU and national developments

What recurring job should this agent perform better or more consistently?

Step 2. Define the need

Complete this sentence: this agent helps [WHO] to [DO WHAT] so that [WHY].

For example: this agent helps the communications team prepare speech drafts so that we produce a strong first version faster while preserving the speaker's style.

Should this actually be an agent?

- A conversation, if it is one-off or exploratory.
- A reusable prompt, if it is the same task with little persistent context.
- An agent, if it has a recurring purpose plus instructions, knowledge and boundaries.

Step 3. Design the agent

Building block	Question to answer
Purpose	What job does the agent exist to do?
Context	What does it need to know before starting?
Method	What steps should it follow?
Knowledge	What information should it use and trust?
Boundaries	What should it never assume or do?
Output	What should a good answer look like?
Oversight	What should a human still check or decide?

Now turn those blocks into a workflow. For each stage decide what the agent does, what it needs, the rule it follows, and what could go wrong.

Step	What it does	What it needs	Main rule	What could go wrong

1 Understand	Establish audience, occasion and objective	The request	Ask if essential context is missing	Writes for the wrong audience
2 Retrieve	Find relevant material and precedents	Trusted sources	Prioritise approved sources	Uses outdated material
3 Develop	Identify messages and build structure	Sources and the objective	Preserve factual nuance	Introduces unsupported claims
4 Draft	Produce it in the right style	Previous examples	Adapt rather than copy	Sounds generic
5 Check	Review facts, tone and attribution	Draft and sources	Flag anything needing verification	Confident about the uncertain
6 Deliver	Produce a usable draft for review	Checked draft	Mark what still needs judgement	Mistaken for approved messaging

Step 4. Turn the design into instructions

PASTE INTO YOUR ASSISTANT

Turn the agent design below into clear instructions for an AI agent.

AGENT DESIGN:

[PASTE YOUR DESIGN FROM STEP 3 HERE]

Step 5. Stress-test it

Do not only test with an easy request. Give it three.

Test 1, a normal request

Prepare talking points for this event using the attached briefing.

Test 2, missing context

Write something about this.

Does it ask for what it genuinely needs, or does it guess?

Test 3, a boundary it cannot reliably cross

Tell me what (ORGANISATION)'s position will be on this issue next year.

Does it respect the limit and say so?

Step 6. Improve one thing

After testing, do not rewrite everything. Identify the biggest failure, change one instruction, and test again. Design, test, observe, refine.

Final reflection

- What recurring problem does my agent solve?
- What knowledge does it need?
- What method should it follow?
- What are its most important boundaries?
- Where must a human remain in control?